



Dear Review Committee Members,

I am writing to strongly support Dr. Jose Zevallos's Merit Review Award application titled "*Optimizing HPV Vaccination Strategies for Head and Neck Cancer Prevention in Veterans*". I am an Assistant Professor in the Department of Biostatistics and Health Data Science at the University of Pittsburgh School of Public Health, and my research focuses on causal discovery and inference, simulation modeling for infectious diseases, and integration of complex data using VA informatics platforms. I also serve as Research Biostatistician at the Center for Healthcare Evaluation, Research, and Promotion at the, VA Pittsburgh Healthcare System. I am eager to serve as a Co-Investigator on this project and to contribute my expertise to help ensure its success and scientific rigor.

As part of this proposal, I will take a leading role in Aim 2, which involves developing and implementing a simulation modeling framework to estimate the public health impact of expanding HPV vaccination eligibility among the Veteran population. I will work closely with the investigative team to design the model structure, set parameters for HPV infection and cancer progression pathways, incorporate VHA-specific epidemiologic data, and ensure the model accurately reflects the demographic, behavioral, and clinical characteristics of Veterans. This will enable us to estimate reductions in HPV infections, oropharyngeal cancer incidence, cancer-related mortality, and associated gains in quality-adjusted life years. In Aim 3, I will collaborate closely with Co-Investigator Dr. Praveen Kumar to develop the economic evaluation framework that uses simulation outputs to estimate long-term costs, potential savings, and cost-effectiveness of expanded HPV vaccination within the VHA. My contributions will include designing the cost-effectiveness model, integrating VHA treatment and utilization data, performing scenario analyses, and interpreting results to inform VHA policy.

I have the necessary experience and expertise directly support the proposed work, especially since this project involves integrating real-world VHA data with simulation modeling to project long-term health and economic outcomes. The Veteran population has unique risk profiles, age distributions, and comorbidity patterns that make general population models inadequate, underscoring the need for this Veteran-specific modeling effort.

I am dedicated to supporting all aspects of the analytical approach, participating in team meetings, assisting with interpreting and sharing findings, and ensuring that the resulting models are rigorous, transparent, and useful for guiding VHA policy decisions regarding HPV vaccination eligibility.

This proposal addresses a critical gap in prevention strategies for HPV-associated oropharyngeal cancer and has substantial potential to inform national VHA guidelines and reduce disease burden. I am pleased to contribute my expertise to this high-impact project and fully support its scientific merit, feasibility, and relevance to Veteran health.

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Signed by:

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Sincerely,
Soumik Purkayastha.

11-20-2025 | 4:50 PM EST